

FLAGS



FOR HUNDREDS of years, people have used flags as emblems, signals, or rallying points. Among the earliest flags were those flown in battle, so that soldiers could identify their leader and tell each side apart. The flag has since developed as a means of communication, used to send rapid signals, or as a symbol representing a nation or group. Every country has its own flag, as do many states and most political organizations.



Parts of a flag

A flag is usually made from brightly coloured fabric and is square or rectangular in shape – although more varied shapes, such as streamers, banners, and long, narrow pennons, were once popular. It is divided into four quarters (cantons): those near the pole are the hoist, and the others the fly. A special emblem often appears in the upper hoist canton.

Flying the flag

In Europe, flags are attached to the pole by passing the toggle through a loop (becket) in another rope (halyard). In the USA, flags have eyelets to which clips are attached. Inglefield clips have a quick-release mechanism, and are popular at sea. Parade flagstaves are topped with decorative finials.

First flags

Many ancient armies carried standards, carved symbols on the end of a pole. The Roman standard first introduced cloth flags. These hung from horizontal poles, to make them easy to carry on horseback.

Homemade flag

The first flag was probably a piece of brightly coloured cloth tied to a stick. A plain red flag spelt danger to early peoples, just as it does today.



Pride of a legion

The Roman standard was awarded to a military unit only as a reward for special endeavour.

Uses of flags

Flags communicate across language barriers. At sea, the International Code of Signals is a system of signalling with flags: the meanings are the same in every language. In both sports and politics, flags also send messages that are understood universally.

Rallying cries

Modern flags may be developed to identify political movements, or for international medical or environmental groups. The emblems and colours represent the organization's ideals: for instance, a white background stands for peace, while olive branches symbolize reconciliation.



Red Cross flag



Flag of the United Nations



The dove on the Greenpeace flag, a symbol of hope



Soccer flags are raised to signal when the ball has gone out of play.



Golf flags are attached to slender pins to mark the holes on a course.

Sports flags

Flags are used in many sports for marking out the area of play or signalling to participants.



Plastic marker flags

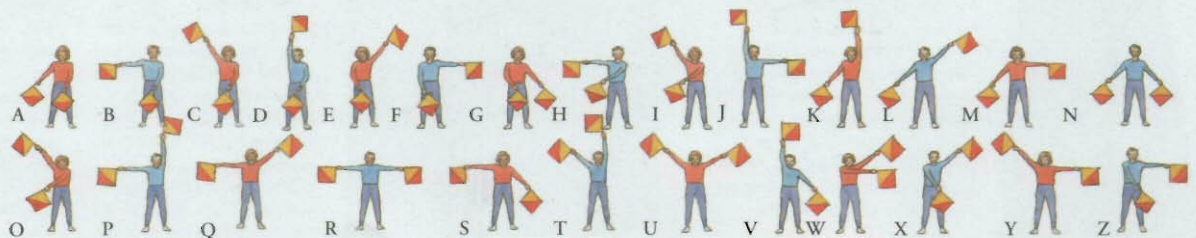
Political symbols

A symbol on a national flag can sum up political ideals that would otherwise take many words. The former Soviet red flag with its hammer and sickle symbol represented the workers and farmers who took part in the Russian Revolution.



Semaphore

This method of signalling with just two flags is still used at sea. Signallers can spell out a message quickly, simply by changing the position of their arms. Red and yellow flags are chosen because they can be seen over long distances.



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